

By Dr. Ilana Gurevich



*Rebuild your
Microbiome*

Why the microbiome matters

Over the years in practice, I've come to see the microbiome not as a trend or a buzzword, but as a central regulator of physiology. When someone walks into my office with bloating, food sensitivity, irregular stools, hormone shifts, immune reactivity, or fatigue, I don't just ask what they're eating — I ask what ecosystem is living inside them.

Your gut microbiome is not simply a collection of bacteria. It is a dynamic, metabolically active system that helps determine how you digest food, regulate inflammation, metabolize hormones, and communicate with your nervous system. It produces short-chain fatty acids that nourish your colon cells. It influences bile metabolism. It interacts with estrogen. It helps train your immune system to respond appropriately instead of react excessively.

When this system is diverse and resilient, the body tends to feel more stable. Digestion is smoother. Reactions are fewer. Energy is steadier. Hormonal transitions feel less chaotic.

When diversity declines or function becomes impaired, symptoms often begin to emerge — not because the body is failing, but because regulation has shifted.

The empowering part of this conversation is this: the microbiome is adaptive. It responds to what we eat, how we prepare our food, how we move, how we sleep, and how we manage stress. It is not fixed.

This book is not here to “hack” your microbiome. It is here to help it do what it was supposed to do... thrive!

What the studies show

When we talk about food as medicine, the science of how diet shapes the gut microbiome is one of the most compelling parts of the story. In a well-controlled study published in **Cell**, researchers asked a simple but powerful question: How do two different microbiome-targeted diets — one high in fiber and one high in fermented foods — change the gut microbiome and immune status in healthy adults?

Participants were randomized to either a high-fiber diet or a high-fermented-food diet and followed for a total of about 17 weeks. What we see again and again in nutrition science is that diet really does matter — but the effects are distinct depending on the type of food you prioritize.

For those eating more fermented foods — think yogurt, kefir, sauerkraut, kimchi, and similar foods — the results were striking. Over time their gut microbiomes became more diverse, which is something we almost always associate with better resilience, metabolic flexibility, and lower inflammation. At the same time, markers of systemic inflammation decreased across the group. In practical terms, this suggests that regularly including fermented foods may help build a more robust and anti-inflammatory microbial ecosystem.

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Home Made Yogurt

Home Made Dairy Yogurt

Servings: 12

Prep Time: 5 minutes

Fermentation Time: 24 hours

Ingredients:

- Quart of whole organic milk
- Quart of 1/2 and 1/2 or cream
- Yogurtmate packets or previous yogurt (i.e. 1/4 cup of Nancy's yogurt)

Directions:

Bring quart of milk and 1/2 and 1/2 to a boil.

Let cool to room temperature

Mix in either packet of starter of 1/4 cup Nancy's per cup milk and dilute

Put in yogurt maker for 24 hours

After that eat and enjoy - store in the refrigerator

Home Made Vegan Yogurt

Servings:

12

Prep Time:

5 minutes

Fermentation Time:

24 hours

Ingredients:

- Two 13.5 oz cans pure coconut milk
- 1 1/2 teaspoons unflavored gelatin
- 1 packet of non-dairy yogurt starter or 2 good quality probiotic capsule

Directions:

-Heat the coconut milk over medium to medium-high heat until it reaches 115 degrees, making sure to stir the milk constantly. Do not allow the milk to come to a boil.

Once the coconut milk comes to temp, turn off the burner and move the saucepan to a cooler area on the stovetop.

Allow milk to cool to 110 degrees. (This won't take long, since it's such a small temperature difference.)

When milk reaches 110 degrees, thoroughly whisk in the gelatin for about one minute. And then add the non-dairy yogurt starter and continue to whisk until thoroughly combined, about one minute.

Home Made Vegan Yogurt

continued:

Directions:

Place the yogurt mixture into a yogurt maker, or use another reliable incubation method as outlined in the photo tutorial.

Allow yogurt to culture for 10-18 hours. The longer you culture, the more tangy the taste.

Then give it a good whisking to re-blend, and transfer it to the refrigerator to cool completely.

Once chilled, thoroughly whisk the yogurt again to blend it together, since separation commonly occurs.

Cover and store in fridge. Or transfer the yogurt to individual serving containers, if desired.



Fermented Vegetables

Kim Chi

Servings: 12

Prep Time: 30 minutes

Fermentation Time: 1-5 days

Soaking time 2 hours

Ingredients:

1 Medium Head Napa Cabbage

¼ Cup Salt (Iodine Free)

1 Tablespoon Grated Garlic

1 Teaspoon Grated Ginger

1 Teaspoon Sugar

2 Tablespoons Fish Sauce

1-5 Tablespoons Gochugaru (Korean red pepper flakes)

8 Ounces Daikon Raddish

4 Medium Scallions

Directions:

Cut the cabbage lengthwise through the stem into quarters. Cut the cores from each piece. Cut each quarter crosswise into 2-inch-wide strips. - Using the food processor would speed up this step

Place the cabbage in a large bowl and sprinkle with the salt.

Using your hands, massage the salt into the cabbage until it starts to soften a bit.

Add enough water to cover the cabbage. Put a plate and weighted object on top of the cabbage and weigh it down with something heavy, like a jar or can of beans. Let stand for 1 to 2 hours.

Kim Chi

continued:

Directions:

Rinse the cabbage under cold water. Set aside to drain in a colander for 15 to 20 minutes.

Make spice paste -

Add the garlic, ginger, sugar, and fish sauce and stir into a smooth paste.

Stir in the gochugaru, using 1 tablespoon for mild and up to 5 tablespoons for spicy

Squeeze any remaining water from the cabbage and add it to the spice paste. Add the radish and scallions.

Using your hands (gloved hands are fine), work the paste into the vegetables until they are thoroughly coated.

Pack the kimchi into a 1-quart jar. Press down on the kimchi until the brine (the liquid that comes out) rises to cover the vegetables, leaving at least 1 inch of space at the top. Seal the jar.

Place a bowl or plate under the jar to help catch any overflow. Let the jar stand at cool room temperature, out of direct sunlight, for 1 to 5 days. You may see bubbles inside the jar and brine may seep out of the lid.

Check the kimchi once a day, opening the jar and pressing down on the vegetables to keep them submerged under the brine.

When the kimchi tastes ripe enough for your liking, transfer the jar to the refrigerator. You may eat it right away, but it's best after another week or two.

Sauerkraut

Servings: 12

Prep Time: 30 minutes

Fermentation Time: 1-5 days

Soaking time 2 hours

Ingredients:

1 head Green Cabbage

Salt - 1 1/2-2
teaspoons salt for
every pound of
cabbage

Directions:

Cut the cabbage in half and remove the core.
Slice the cabbage very thinly, approximately 1/8
inch thick.

Place the sliced cabbage in a large bowl and
toss in the salt.

Let it sit for about 20 minutes until the cabbage
has begun to wilt and releases some of its
juices.

Use a masher to crush the cabbage until it is
wilted and has released a lot of liquid.

Transfer the cabbage and all the juices to a
glass jar

Sauerkraut

continued:

Directions:

Mash the cabbage down so it fills the jar $\frac{2}{3}$ full

Continue to mash the cabbage with the tamper, releasing more juice, until the cabbage is completely submerged under the brine and any air pockets have been removed - this is important to prevent mold and pathogenic bacterial overgrowth

Make sure cabbage remain submerged under the brine during fermentation process

Place the jars in a dark place that is between 65-70 degrees F, the ideal temperature for fermenting.

Ferment for 14-21 days depending on flavor preference

Once your desired flavor is achieved store the sauerkraut in the fridge.

Fermentation won't stop but it will be greatly slowed down.



Fermented Drinks

Fermented Drinks

There are many hundreds of recipes for fermented beverages, such as meads, wines, and ciders, ale lager, vinegar, as well as Kombucha Tea. The following list of lesser known types of fermented drinks was sent into the Kombucha mailing list by Günther Frank, the well known author of a book written about Kombucha Tea, entitled: "Kombucha - Healthy Beverage and Natural Remedy from the Far East".



Water Kefir

Servings: 8

Prep Time: 10 minutes

Fermentation Time: 24-72 hours

Ingredients:

Quart Jar, Clean Towel
and a rubber band

3 Cups Filtered Water

¼ cup organic sugar

100 grams Water Kefir
Grains

Directions:

Dissolve ¼ cup sugar in filtered water and allow
water to cool

Add kefir grains into the water and sugar
mixture

Place a breathable cover over the opening of
the jar and secure it with a rubber band. Place
the jar in a warm location (Ideally 76-78°F) out
of direct sunlight and let it ferment

Allow mixture to sit on counter for 24-72 hours
(depending on desired taste).

Strain out kefir grains - and re-use for the next
batch.

Leave in refrigerator and enjoy for the next 7
days

Kombucha

Servings:

12

Prep Time:

10 minutes

Fermentation Time:

7 days

Ingredients:

Gallon Jar, Clean Towel
and a rubber band

1 Gallon Filtered Water

1 Cup Sugar

Tea: - 6-8 bags of
black tea, green tea, or
a mix (or 2 tablespoons
loose-leaf tea)

1 Kombucha SCOBY

Directions:

Boil & Steep: Bring 1 quart of water to a boil. Remove from heat, add sugar, and stir until dissolved. Add tea bags or loose tea and steep for 10-15 minutes.

Cool: Remove the tea bags. Pour the hot concentrated tea into your 1-gallon glass jar and top with the remaining 3 quarts of cold, filtered water to help it cool faster.

Add SCOBY & Starter: Once the tea is cool to room temperature (below 90°F), add the SCOBY and the starter tea.

Cover & Ferment: Cover the jar with the cloth and secure it with a rubber band to prevent fruit flies. Place it in a warm, dark spot (70-80°F) for 7-10 days.

Fizzy Kombucha

Servings:

12

Prep Time:

2 minutes

Fermentation Time:

3-7 days

Ingredients:

Home Made Kombucha

Directions:

Pour the fermented kombucha into air-tight glass bottles (swing-top bottles are ideal).

Add flavorings (e.g., 2-4 tablespoons of fruit juice, fruit puree, or herbs per 16 oz).

Seal tightly and let sit at room temperature for 3-7 days for carbonation.

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This Is Not a Protocol. It's a Foundation

If there is one thing I want you to take from this guide, it is this:

Your microbiome is not fragile. - It is adaptive.

It responds to consistency more than intensity. It responds to preparation more than perfection. And it responds to diversity over restriction.

Fermented foods are physiologic tools the all humans have historically used.

You do not need to overhaul your life overnight. You do not need to eliminate everything. You do not need to chase symptoms.

You need to support your ecosystem.

When digestion stabilizes, inflammation often quiets. When diversity improves, resilience follows. When preparation improves, tolerance often improves.

Start small.

Add slowly.

Be consistent.

Let your microbiome do what it was designed to do.

Follow Dr. G

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the integrative gastroenterology podcast

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gastroenterology podcast
discusses functional GI
conditions and treatments*



*A podcast exploring
practical tools addressing
autonomic nervous system
disorders*

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This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The paper has a decorative, scalloped border along all four edges. At the top center, the word "Notes" is written in a large, elegant, black serif font. Below the title, there are approximately 20 horizontal lines spaced evenly apart, providing space for writing notes.